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Generational Effects of Racial Discrimination

Racial discrimination in one era contributes to chronic wealth gaps in future generations. The discrimination and unequal access to resources are depicted in the realistic fiction novel *To Kill a Mockingbird*, written by Harper Lee, and are also apparent in the real world. *To Kill a Mockingbird* shows the racial prejudices and injustices throughout society in Maycomb, Alabama, from the viewpoint of a young girl named Scout. Her father, Atticus Finch, is one of the few white people in Maycomb who genuinely believe that black people should have the same rights as everyone else. He raises his family by teaching concepts and lessons to Scout and her older brother Jem. Atticus is a lawyer who defends Tom Robinson, who is falsely accused of raping a white woman. Scout and Jem watch from the segregated courtroom balcony and come to understand the racial relationships in Maycomb. There are numerous examples of racial discrimination in society and data showing the subsequent unequal distribution of opportunity. This opportunity manifests as the economic distribution of wealth, resources, and power that all races do not have equal access to. Wealth, education, employment for jobs, health, shelter, and many other indicators have racial disparities. Government laws and policies can exacerbate the inability of historically marginalized people to benefit from their nation's prosperity. The issue that racial discrimination correlates to racial inequality shows in *To Kill a Mockingbird*, from the unequal treatment in the Tom Robinson court case to the racially segregated churches, and the issue is also apparent in the real world with the establishment of the Jim Crow laws, and

anti-Asian sentiment, as exemplified by the manifestation of Japanese people's forced internment into camps.

The novel reflects the idea that black people are subjected to unlawful discrimination and segregation solely based on the color of their skin, which leads to the overall racial inequality of Maycomb. In the trial described in the novel, Atticus defended Tom Robinson, whom Mr. Ewell accused of raping Mayella Ewell. Atticus projects numerous ways that this was false and that actually Mr. Ewell had beaten Mayella. One of his defense arguments was that Tom Robinson stood up and revealed his mangled left arm, but the bruises were on Mayella's right side. In fact, Atticus showed that it was Mr. Ewell who was left-handed by his signing of a piece of paper. Despite overwhelming reasonable doubt about Tom Robinson's guilt, he was not acquitted. This guilty verdict is a microcosm of the injustice that black people endure, as after all of Atticus's intricate work of revealing the truth while embarrassing Mr. Ewell, just because of the racist beliefs of the white-run society, the jury ruled Tom Robinson guilty. The color of a person's skin dictates their life. Black people are often in impossible predicaments; for example, Tom Robinson "would not have dared strike a white woman under any circumstances and expect to live long, so he took the first opportunity to run—a sure sign of guilt" (Lee 221). In Maycomb, it is nearly impossible for a black person to have equal opportunity for justice, even though supposedly "in this country our courts are the great levelers, and in our courts all men are created equal" (Lee 233). With no proof, white people sentence black people. Furthermore, unequal wealth distribution caused by systemic discrimination compounds the problem because black people do not have the money to hire persuasive lawyers like Atticus and instead get sent to jail or are given a death sentence. Even with the help of Atticus, who defends black people, society still chooses to find the black person guilty. Next, the novel portrays Scout and Jem visiting

Calpurnia's black church, which is separate from the white church; the black church is not as fancy or clean as the white church, for example, "if someone died during a dry spell, the body was covered with chunks of ice until rain softened the earth" (Lee 134). The bodies cannot be buried appropriately during the winter as they cannot access expensive tools. If white people did not discriminate against black people, all people would be allowed to attend the same churches, facilitating advancements for all. The novel encompasses white people's judgment of other people based on their skin color, which results in their reduced ability to thrive.

The racial discrimination and inequality by whites against minority ethnic groups are not only present in the novel *To Kill a Mockingbird* but are also reflected throughout the history of the United States. Between 1877 and the mid-1960s, a racial caste system called the Jim Crow laws "enforced segregation and severely limited opportunities for non-white Americans" (Bowdler and Harris). It separated white and black races, and that discrimination encouraged white supremacy against African Americans. This injustice created significant unfairness as people who had black skin were not allowed to have a free and everyday lifestyle. The inequality for black people structurally hindered their economic and social advancement. The Jim Crow laws deprived opportunity for advancement, which carried over for generations in the future. In the United States in 2020, even with substantially less racial discrimination, the median household income of black people is still only \$46,000, compared to that of \$75,000 for white people (Bowdler and Harris). This disparity shows the challenging progression for black people from having an unequal and more discriminated past. Racial discrimination was not only limited to targeting black people; anti-Asian sentiment has likewise existed for over 100 years. For example, Japanese families were discriminated against during World War II, as manifested by "the forced relocation and internment of about 120,000 Japanese Americans" (Bowdler and

Harris) solely based on their ethnicity. These families could not gain jobs and garner the benefits one would expect with a life of freedom. They were stuck in the camps and, even upon release, were discriminated against, creating a lasting effect on their ability to have equal access to the benefits of modern economy and society. In summary, there are numerous events across American history of harmful and inequitable policies against minority ethnic groups.

In conclusion, the correlation between racial discrimination and racial inequality is evident in the novel *To Kill a Mockingbird* from the prejudiced discrimination of the treatment of Tom Robinson in his trial and from the segregation of white and black churches, and the correlation is also prevalent in real-world history as seen in the racial caste system of Jim Crow, and the manifestation of Japanese people being sent to internment camps due to anti-Asian sentiment. The unlawful and segregated racial events in *To Kill a Mockingbird* are a realistic interpretation of the discriminatory treatment of black people during the 1930s. As exemplified by the Tom Robinson court case, the institutionally rigged system is working against black people; Atticus teaches this concept to his children when he explains the whites have “done it before, and they did it tonight, and they’ll do it again, and when they do it—seems that only children weep” (Lee 243). Only the children, like Scout and Jem, have yet to be indoctrinated into this mindset of inequality. The favored white adults in Maycomb have been corrupted to be institutionalized and cannot help but continue to discriminate against black people. Countless events prove the injustice of law and segregation in the real world. The Jim Crow laws effectively blocked the advancement of black people in society, not unlike how internment camps and subsequent racial discrimination hindered Asians’ ability to advance. Economic data in the United States quantifies the differences in the distribution of wealth across minority groups, and in *To Kill a Mockingbird*, it is readily apparent that wealth is similarly distributed

unequally between the white and black populations. Different minority groups are being unfairly discriminated against and segregated based on their skin color. Institutional racial discrimination leads to a chronic and unequal distribution of a nation's resources.

Works Cited

- Bowdler, Janis, and Benjamin Harris. "Racial Inequality in the United States." *U.S. Department of the Treasury*, United States Government, 21 July 2022, home.treasury.gov/news/featured-stories/racial-inequality-in-the-united-states. Accessed 5 Feb. 2023.
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